

mies, and each area has some strategic vantage point overlooking each cover space. The enemies thrown at you also vary. There are some who will run at you with melee weapons, other heavily armoured enemies with shotguns who will slowly come at you, some snipers, and a hoard of assault rifle-wielding goons that will flank you from all possible angles. Needless to say, the action can get quite frantic.

The Pyromancer has many abilities such as setting enemies ablaze, absorbing enemy's health, freezing enemies in place using an 'Ash' ability, a blast that sets close-by enemies ablaze and more. The more you use your special abilities, the more chance you have of surviving an encounter.

In addition to the diverse set of enemies, the game also throws some 'Altered' enemies at you with the same ability as you or one of the four classes mentioned above, adding a unique twist to the combat. You have a window of opportunity to stop them from making a special attack, and it's the fights with the altered enemies that serve as the heated boss battles in the game.

When it comes to weapons, you can carry two weapons with you in addition to a side-arm and, as with any looter shooter, you can upgrade the stats of the weapons you collect. You can also add some special buffs to the weapons giving you abilities like momentarily freezing an enemy in place, or setting them ablaze, or giving you some shield protection; the list is quite long. You can also customise the armour you collect and add these buffs to them as well.

As you progress through the game, you level up your character and increase the world tier. Think of the world tier as the difficulty of the game. The higher the world tier, the more challenging the enemies, the rarer the loot they drop. This encourages you to play at the highest world tier available.



But if you feel a particular encounter is too tough for you, you can always reduce the world tier to reduce the difficulty and get past the challenge.

Overall, it's the gameplay more than anything else that kept me hooked and coming back for more.

GRAPHICS

I played Outriders on a PS5, and the first thing to talk about is the load times. Once you've logged into the server, all loading happened in under 5 seconds. It was pretty tough to log in on the launch weekend of the game; why can't the game be played offline in single-player mode?

Moving on, the game ran at 60 fps with some minor dips here and there. The game overall runs fluid, and 60 fps is

much appreciated, especially during the frantic battles.

This comes at the cost of resolution, as you can make out some low-quality textures here and there. The characters' facial animation is nothing to write home about, but a lot of their armour and clothing look rich.

You can jump into the menu to take a close look at some of the guns, and their designs are unique.

SOUND

The voice acting is right out of a cheesy Hollywood flick and in line with what one would expect from the story. It's the sound effects of the explosions and guns that will hit your ears the most. In this respect, the sniper rifle has a nice loud thud to it, while the assault rifles have a consistent battering repetition one would expect. Even your unique altered abilities have a good wiggle and swoops when used. While the background score and voice acting aren't great, the game's overall sound design is sufficient to get you through the game.

VERDICT

Outriders is a fun ride while it lasts. I wish I could test ride all the classes before settling on one, but that's one gripe in an otherwise fun

game. Whether you are looking for a looter shooter solo experience or a night of social distancing gaming with friends online, Outriders has combat that's frantic enough to keep you at the edge of your seat, ensuring you feel like you achieved victory at the end of every battle. Be it solo or with friends, that's the most important feeling. The story and music won't appeal to all, but you'll be hooked if you enjoy the gameplay. *

MOAR!

TESTED ON:
PS5

DEVELOPER:
People Can Fly

PUBLISHER:
Square Enix

PLATFORMS:
PS4, PS5, Xbox One, Xbox Series X/S, PC and Stadia.

PRICE:
₹3,999 for consoles,
₹2,999 for PC.